

ART & CULTURE



RELIGION AND PHILOSOPHY

MODULE - 5

BUDDHISM- IMPORTANT PLACES AND MUDRAS

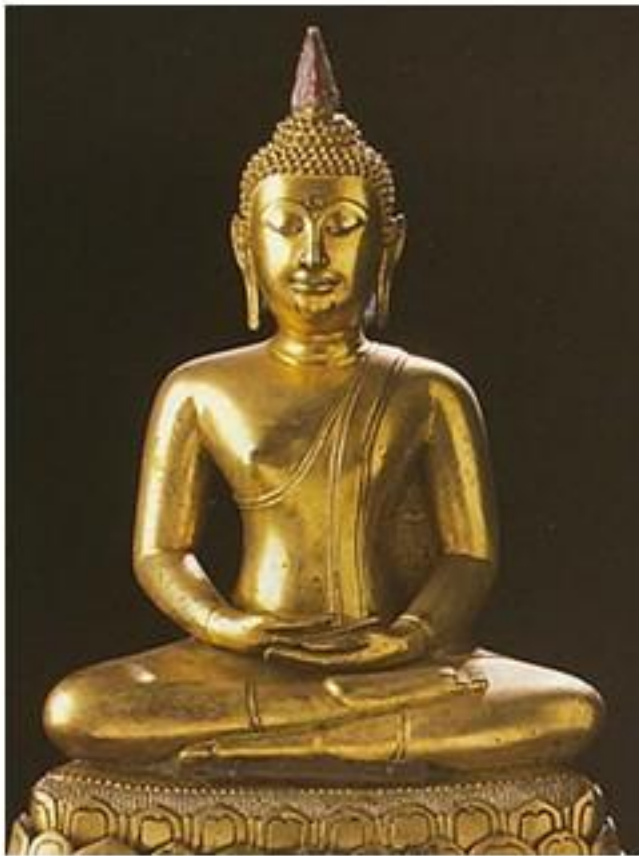
BUDDHISM

MUDRAS IN BUDDHISM



- 1** In early Buddhism, statues of Buddha were not made and Buddha was represented through symbols.
- 2** The practice of making Buddha's statues came in vogue in the later Buddhist tradition, particularly in the Mahayana form of Buddhism where Buddha was shown in seated or standing pose with various hand gestures called the "Mudras". Some of the important ones are described below.

MUDRAS IN BUDDHISM



1

DHYANA MUDRA:

- This is among the most common of mudras in which Buddha is depicted.
- He is shown to be seated in lotus posture while both his hands are placed on the lap.
- The palm is open and facing upward, with fingers stretched.
- The right palm is over left and the eyes are closed in meditation.

MUDRAS IN BUDDHISM



2

ABHAYA MUDRA:

- This is a posture of fearlessness and also blessing.
- The right arm of Buddha is shown to be elevated and bent slightly.
- The palm is facing outward and fingers are extended upwards.
- This mudras is also a common one showing a peaceful Buddha in benediction.

MUDRAS IN BUDDHISM



3

BHUMISPASHA MUDRA:

- Buddha is shown to be seated in lotus posture (Padmasana) with his right palm hanging on the right knee and the fingers touching the Earth.
- The left hand rests on the lap with palm upwards. It symbolizes **Buddha calling the Earth to be his witness to his victory over Mara** (Mara is a demon representing passion trying to entice Buddha into worldly pleasures).

BUDDHISM

MUDRAS IN BUDDHISM



4

KARANA MUDRA:

- This gesture signifies the **warding off evil** which is performed by raising the index and the little finger, and folding the other fingers.
- It helps in **reducing sickness or negative thoughts**.

MUDRAS IN BUDDHISM



5

VARADA MUDRA:

- In this Mudra, Buddha is shown to be **conferring his grace or blessings**.
- The arm is shown extended all the way down with the palm facing outward.
- Buddha is mostly depicted in a standing position in this mudra.

MUDRAS IN BUDDHISM



6

DHARMACHAKRA MUDRA:

- It is also called as the gesture of 'Teaching of the Wheel of Dharma' that describes one of the most important moments in the Buddha's life as he performed the Dharmachakra mudra in his first sermon in Sarnath after he attained enlightenment.
- It is performed with the help of both the hands which are held against the chest, the left facing inward, covering the right facing outward.

BUDDHISM

MUDRAS IN BUDDHISM



7

VAJRA MUDRA:

- This gesture denotes the fiery thunderbolt gesture
- It symbolizes the five elements of nature.

MUDRAS IN BUDDHISM



8 VIDHARKA MUDRA:

- It signifies the **discussion and transmission of the teachings of the Buddha.**
- It is performed by joining the **tips of the thumb and the index fingers together while keeping the other fingers straight**, which is just like Abhaya Mundra but in this Mundra the thumbs are touching the index fingers.

MUDRAS IN BUDDHISM



9

UTTARABODHI MUDRA:

- This gesture denotes the **supreme enlightenment** through **connecting oneself with divine universal energy**.
- It is performed with the help of both the hand, which placed at the heart and the index fingers touching and pointing upwards and the remaining fingers intertwined.

MUDRAS IN BUDDHISM



10 ANJALI MUDRA:

- It is also called '**Namaskara Mudra**' or '**Hridayanjali Mudra**'.
- It represents the gesture of greeting, prayer and adoration.
- It is performed by pressing the palms of the hands together in which the hands are held close to the heart.

BUDDHISM

PLACES ASSOCIATED WITH LIFE OF BUDDHA

ASTAMAHASTHANAS

There are eight great holy places associated with the life of Buddha

LUMBINI

- Located in Nepal
- Birth place of Buddha

BODHGAYA

- Place of enlightenment
- Located in Bihar on bank of river Neranjana {also known as Uruwela at that time}

SARNATH

- Also known as Isipatana
- Deliver first sermon at deer park

KUSHINAGAR

- Noted Buddhist site marking his place of death.

BUDDHISM

PLACES ASSOCIATED WITH LIFE OF BUDDHA

SRAVASTI

- Buddha spent a major portion of his life here.
- Important for Jains also.
- In Buddha time, it was the capital of Kosala Kingdom.

SANKASYA

- Farrukhabad district of Uttar Pradesh
- Currently it has ruins of old monasteries and Buddhist monuments.

RAJGIR

- It is sacred to the founders of both the historical Mahavira and Buddha.
- Buddha delivered some of his famous sermons and initiated king Bimbisara of Magadha and countless others to Buddhism.

VAISHALI

- During his time Vajji Mahajanapada.
- After leaving Kapilavastu for renunciation, he came to Vaishali first and had his spiritual training.

OTHER PLACES OF IMPORTANCE IN BUDDHISM

AMARAVATI

- AP's Guntur district
- Site of a Buddhist Stupa built in pre-Mauryan times, ruled by Satavahana kings.

NAGARJUNKONDA

- near Nagarjunasagar in AP
- Home to more than 30 Buddhist Viharas.
- named after Nagarjuna, a renowned Buddhist scholar and philosopher
- Remains were discovered in 1926 by archaeologist AR Saraswati in 1926.

AJANTA CAVES

- It have 31 rock cut caves from 2nd to 8th century AD, located in Aurangabad
- first caves called Chaityas were created during Satavahana Dynasty
- Cave No. 1 has the painting of Padmapani and Vajrapani
- Jataka tales are depicted on the walls.

ANGKOR WAT

- located in Cambodia
- temple were built by Suryavarman II
- first devoted to Vishnu and later to Buddhist.

OTHER PLACES OF IMPORTANCE IN BUDDHISM

BODH GAYA

- It has Mahabodhi temple and Bodhi tree
- Later, Mahabodhi temple became UNESCO world heritage site in 2002.

BOROBUDUR

- Located in Indonesia
- It is a UNESCO World Heritage site

BAMYAN CAVES

- located in Afghanistan
- Made in Gandhara Style.
- Largest examples of standing Buddha
- Blown by dynamite by Taliban in 2001

ELLORA CAVES

- It has Buddhist, Jain and Hindu Rock cut temples built by Rashtrakuta Kings
- Most caves of Buddhism are Viharas.

OTHER PLACES OF IMPORTANCE IN BUDDHISM

PUSHPAGIRI UNIVERSITY

- It was an ancient Buddhist mahavihara located atop Langudi Hills in Jajpur district of Odisha, India.
- The visit of Xuanzang indicates that Pushpagiri was an important Buddhist site in ancient India.
- Along with Nalanda, Vikramashila, Odantapuri, Takshashila and Vallabhi, it is believed to be a major ancient centre of learning.

VIKRAMSHILA, AND ODANTAPURI

- Vikramashila and Odantapuri were the Buddhist Viharas founded by Palas.



Ruins of Vikramashila University

BUDDHISM

SCHISMS IN BUDDHISM



- 1 The **Second Buddhist Council** was convened at Vaishali a century after the death of the Buddha (around 383 BC presided over by Sabakami).
- 2 Its purpose was **to end the controversy** between the monks who began to follow some unorthodox practices, and their opponents who remained orthodox.
- 3 But unfortunately it failed to arrive at an agreement over monastic discipline, **leading to the division of the Buddhist Sangha** into the **orthodox Sthaviravadins (or Theravadins)** and the **unorthodox Mahasanghikas**.

MAJOR SCHISM

- 1 One of the earliest schisms in Buddhism occurred in Second Council at Vaisali, and resulted in division of the Buddhists into Sthaviravadins and Mahasanghikas.
- 2 But the major schism occurred in **fourth Buddhist council in Kashmir** and led to the **division of Buddhists into Mahayanists and Hinayanists**.

MINOR SCHISM

- 1 During the second and third centuries new subdivisions came into being, with the result that many sects appeared out of the original groups (Sthaviravadins and Mahasanghikas).
- 2 Some of these sects became important in course of time and had a large following and a literature peculiar to their schools.
- 3 The Mahasanghikas were the precursors of what later came to be called the Mahayanists.
- 4 The Sthaviravadins, further giving rise to other sub groups, had their own literatures of Sutras, etc.

STHAVIRAVADINS

- 1 The earliest and, at the same time, a vivid and simple picture of the personality of the Buddha and his teachings is found in the Pali literature of the Theravadins or Sthaviravadins.
- 2 This literature also describes Buddha as god of gods (devatideva), and capable of being a world teacher.

SARVASTIVADINS

- 1 The Sarvastivadins closely related with the school of Theravada.
- 2 The school of the Sarvastivadins is centred round the idea, **sabbam atthi (all things exist)**.
- 4 This school and that of the Sthaviravadins are **realists**. For them, the external world and its constituent parts, have a real existence.
- 5 Therefore this school believes that all **things exist, and exist continuously—**in the past and the future as well as in the present.

MAHASANGHIKAS

1 They believed in the **transcendent nature of the Buddhas** and therefore all sorts of superhuman powers were attributed to them.

2 The distinguishing character was that **greater importance was attached to the Bodhisattvas**, as they were considered to possess paranormal powers and to have been more helpful to the world.

- To a certain extent, it can be said that the above sects and subsects belong to Hinayana.
- However, some of the sects, held views which were partially Mahayanic as well and may be looked upon as the precursors of Mahayana doctrines.
- For instance, the Mahasanghikas deified the Buddha and also introduced the the Bodhisattva conception.

PRELIMS 2017 QUESTION

With reference to the religious history of India, consider the following statements:

1. Sautrantika and Sammitiya were the sects of Jainism.
2. Sarvastivadin held that the constituents of phenomena were not wholly momentary, but existed forever in a latent form.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only**
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

CAUSES FOR THE DECLINE OF BUDDHISM

1

Deterioration of moral standards in Buddhism.
Eg: Idol Worship

2

Revival and reforms made in Brahmanism.

3

Buddhism gave up the people's language of Pali and took to Sanskrit, the language of elite.

6

Rise of tantric practices and entry of women in Buddhist order.

5

Attacks of Huns and invasion by the Turks who destroyed the Buddhist monasteries.

4

Persecution of Buddhist monks.

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